

Spain



Following a long period of decline, Spain has made a successful transition from dictatorship to democracy.

218 BCE The boundary between Roman and Carthaginian Spain lies along the Ebro River.

206 BCE Spain is conquered by the Romans under Scipio Africanus after his legions have driven out the Carthaginians.

133 BCE The final Celtic resistance to Roman rule is broken when the northern city of Numantia falls after a 20-year war.

419 CE At the end of the Roman Empire, a Visigothic kingdom is established in most of Spain with a Suevic kingdom in the northwest and some Vandal settlements in the far south.

554 Civil war in the Visigothic kingdom gives the Byzantine emperor Justinian the opportunity to reconquer southern Spain.

571 Visigoths recapture Córdoba and the rest of the southern state.

585 Visigoths conquer the Suevic kingdom and rule all of Spain.

587 Visigothic king Recared I converts to Catholicism.

711 The Visigoths are defeated by the Moors from North Africa, who introduce Islam to Spain.

718 The Asturian kingdom of northern Spain wins a decisive victory against the Moors at Covadonga, halting their expansion across the peninsula. The kingdom continues to grow at Muslim Spain's expense over the next century.

756 Spain becomes independent from the rest of the Muslim world when Abd-ar-Rahman founds the Umayyad Emirate at Córdoba. The emirate becomes a caliphate in 929. By this time, Córdoba, the capital city of the Umayyad Emirate, is the largest and one of the most prosperous cities in Western Europe.

778 Charlemagne, king of the Franks, defeats the Moors at Roncesvalles in the Basque country and extends Frankish rule over most of northeast Spain.

812 Discovery of what are claimed to be the bones of St. James the Apostle in Compostela; the town soon becomes second only to Rome as a major pilgrim destination.

900s A series of major Muslim raids are conducted into the kingdom of Asturias and León and the Byzantine-held Balearic Islands, which fall to the Muslims in 903.

962 The Christian reconquest of Spain is launched.

El Escorial

Philip II ordered the building of El Escorial, near Madrid, as a monastery and burial place for Spain's kings. It was begun in 1563 by Juan Bautista de Toledo, a Renaissance Spanish architect who had worked in Italy, and completed in 1584.



1008–31 Civil war breaks out in the Umayyad caliphate.

1100s Arabs introduce the art of papermaking to Europe at the port of Valencia.

1143 Alfonso VII of León recognizes the independence of Portugal.

1212 The extent of Moorish rule is reduced after the Moors suffer a major defeat at the battle of Las Navas de Tolosa. Spain now consists of the kingdoms of León and Navarre in the north, Castile in the center, Aragon in the east, and the Almohad Caliphate in the south. The Muslim Emirate of Mallorca rules the Balearic Islands.

1254 Muslim university founded at Seville. Under Muslim rule, towns such as Seville and Toledo are important centers of Islamic scholarship, enabling the knowledge of classical learning, preserved in Arabic translations and texts, to enter the cathedral schools of Western Europe. Muslim Spain also supports a thriving Jewish population that is tolerated by the Muslim authorities.

1360 Muslim rule in Spain is reduced to just the Emirate of Granada in the far south; the Balearic islands are now under Aragonese rule (since 1287).

1385 A Castilian attempt to conquer Portugal is defeated, preserving Portugal's independence.

1442 Aragon acquires Naples in southern Italy to add to its Mediterranean empire of the Balearics, Sardinia, and Sicily.

1469 The future united kingdom of Spain is created by the marriage of Isabella of Castile to Ferdinand of Aragon.

1474 Isabella becomes queen of Castile on the death of her half-brother Henry IV. Her claim is contested by Henry's heir, Juana la Beltraneja, but is enforced through the skillful generalship of her husband, Ferdinand.

1478 The Spanish Inquisition is formed to test the sincerity of Jewish converts to Christianity. It is not officially abolished until 1834, and acquires a sinister reputation for its work.

1479 Ferdinand becomes king of Aragon. With Isabella, they begin to rule their two kingdoms jointly in 1481.

1492 Spanish forces expel the Moors from Granada, completing the Christian reconquest of Spain.



Moorish ceramics

This delicately patterned ceramic dish dates from the period of the emirate of Granada. Moorish arts and architecture achieved a high degree of sophistication during the 13th and 14th centuries.

1492 Isabella supports Christopher Columbus financially in his voyage to the "New World."

1493 Spain gains Roussillon province in the Pyrenees from France.

1494 Charles VIII of France invades Italy, starting a series of wars with Spain for control of Italy.

1496 Spain establishes Caribbean colony of Santo Domingo in Hispaniola.

1497 Spain takes Melilla in North Africa, going on to acquire Oran in 1509, Algiers and Bougie in 1510, and Tunis in 1535.

1504 On Isabella's death, Ferdinand is recognized as regent for their daughter, Joanna the Mad.

1508–15 Spain colonizes Puerto Rico, Cuba, and Jamaica. In Cuba, the original indigenous people are reduced from 50,000 to about 5,000 in 1550, due to deaths from European diseases against which they have no immunity.

1515 Ferdinand incorporates Navarre into Castile, thus becoming the first king of a united Spain.

1516 Charles of Habsburg becomes Charles I of Spain on the death of his father, Ferdinand. In 1519 he becomes Holy Roman Emperor Charles V, but is

"I have placed under the **dominion of the King and Queen...** a second world through which **Spain**, which was reckoned a poor country, has become the richest."

CHRISTOPHER COLUMBUS, IN A LETTER WRITTEN IN 1500